Comparative Analysis of Educational Transformation in Ireland and the United Kingdom: A Study of Fine Gael and Labour Policy Architectures (2024–2026)

1. Introduction: Two Islands, Divergent Paths, Shared Horizons

The period spanning 2024 to early 2026 represents a watershed moment in the educational histories of the Republic of Ireland and the United Kingdom. Driven by distinct yet overlapping socio-economic pressures—post-pandemic attendance crises, the urgent need for digital and green skills, and the escalating complexity of special educational needs (SEND)—both nations have embarked on ambitious reform agendas. These agendas are shaped decisively by the governing philosophies of Fine Gael in Ireland and the Labour Party in the United Kingdom. This report provides an exhaustive analysis of these parallel achievements, focusing specifically on the ministerial tenures of Simon Harris, Helen McEntee, and Hildegarde Naughton in Ireland, and Bridget Phillipson in the UK. While the geopolitical contexts differ—Ireland operating within the European Union's framework of cohesion and the UK navigating a post-Brexit landscape—the policy instruments deployed reveal a fascinating interplay of divergence and convergence.

In Ireland, the "Republic of Opportunity" narrative championed by Fine Gael has manifested in a rejection of loan-based higher education funding, a consolidation of technological universities, and a therapeutic approach to special education. The timeline of leadership—from Simon Harris's foundational work in Higher Education to the successive tenures of Helen McEntee and Hildegarde Naughton in the Department of Education and Youth throughout 2025—illustrates a continuity of purpose focused on "enabling" potential.[1] Conversely, in the United Kingdom, the Labour government elected in 2024 has framed its mandate around a "Mission to Break Down Barriers to Opportunity".[2] Under Education Secretary Bridget Phillipson, this has necessitated a radical reconstruction of the state's role in skills planning, a controversial restructuring of university finance through international student levies, and a return to "Sure Start" principles in early years provision.

By dissecting these strategies, this report aims not only to catalog achievements but to construct a framework for mutual learning. It argues that while Ireland offers a model for structural stability and vocational parity, the UK offers critical lessons in data-driven targeting and service integration.

2. The Higher Education Revolution: Funding, Structure, and Philosophy

The divergence in higher education policy between Ireland and the UK is perhaps the most profound of any sector. While Ireland has moved steadily away from the "cost-sharing" model toward a state-funded paradigm, the UK has attempted to stabilize a market-based system through innovative, albeit risky, cross-subsidy mechanisms.

2.1 Ireland: Simon Harris and the "Funding the Future" Legacy

Simon Harris, serving as Minister for Further and Higher Education, Research, Innovation and Science before his elevation to Taoiseach, architected a funding model that explicitly rejected the trajectory taken by the UK and the US. The policy framework, *Funding the Future*, settled the existential question of how Irish tertiary education would be financed.

2.1.1 The Rejection of Student Loans

The defining achievement of the Harris tenure was the government decision that "student loans will not form part of the future funding model".[3] This decision was rooted in a political consensus that debt acts as a deterrent to access and a drag on the broader economy. Instead, Harris implemented a multi-funded model comprising:

- **Exchequer Investment:** A commitment to close the core funding gap of €307 million through direct state transfer.[3]
- **The National Training Fund (NTF):** A strategic utilization of the surplus in the NTF—a levy on employers—to fund higher education and skills. This effectively socializes the cost of training, recognizing that employers are the ultimate beneficiaries of a skilled workforce.[4]
- **Fee Reduction:** A progressive reduction in the Student Contribution Fee (effectively tuition). By Budget 2026, postgraduate fee contribution grants were increased to €4,500, significantly lowering the barrier to entry for master's and doctoral candidates.[5]

Insight: This model insulates Irish graduates from the inflationary pressures of debt servicing. By shifting the burden to the Exchequer and the corporate sector (via the NTF), Fine Gael has positioned higher education as a public right rather than a private investment product. This has significant implications for graduate retention; Irish graduates enter the workforce without the "graduate tax" equivalent that reduces disposable income for their UK counterparts.

2.1.2 The Technological University (TU) Transformation

Harris also oversaw the completion of the Technological University landscape. The consolidation of Institutes of Technology into entities like Atlantic Technological University (ATU) and Munster Technological University (MTU) was not merely administrative. It was a legislative effort to grant "parity of esteem" to vocational and technical education.[6]

- **Regional Rebalancing:** The TUs are mandated to drive regional development,

countering the economic gravitation toward Dublin. For instance, ATU's "Greentown Project" on crime networks and SETU's mature student programs illustrate how these institutions are embedded in local social fabrics.[7]

- **Unified Tertiary System:** The creation of a unified system allows for seamless transitions. A student can enter a TU on an apprenticeship and progress to a PhD without changing institutions, dissolving the binary divide that historically separated "learning for work" from "learning for knowledge".[6]

2.2 United Kingdom: Bridget Phillipson and the "Priority" Model

In contrast, Bridget Phillipson inherited a UK higher education sector on the brink of financial insolvency. With tuition fees frozen at £9,250 for nearly a decade and inflation eroding real value, the Labour government's response in 2024–2025 was characterized by crisis management and targeted intervention.

2.2.1 The Return of Maintenance Grants

A headline achievement of the Labour government was the reintroduction of maintenance grants, which had been scrapped by the Conservatives in 2016. However, Phillipson's model differs significantly from previous universal systems.

- **Strict Targeting:** Grants are available only to students from low-income households who are studying "priority courses" aligned with the government's Industrial Strategy.[8]
- **Industrial Alignment:** This policy explicitly links educational support to economic utility. Courses in healthcare, STEM, and construction attract funding, while others do not. This represents a shift toward a utilitarian philosophy of education, where the state subsidizes degrees that yield direct economic returns.[9]

2.2.2 The International Student Levy

To fund these grants without increasing general taxation, Phillipson introduced an **International Student Levy**, set at £925 per student for the 2025/26 academic year.[9]

- **Mechanism:** Universities must pay this levy for every international student they recruit. The revenue is ring-fenced to fund domestic maintenance grants.
- **Strategic Risk:** While politically astute—transferring wealth from international recruitment to domestic poverty reduction—this policy carries systemic risk. It relies on the continued attractiveness of UK universities to international students. If immigration policies or geopolitical shifts reduce international numbers, the funding stream for domestic grants collapses.[11]

Insight: The UK approach is highly engineered. It attempts to correct market failures (lack of domestic skills) by leveraging market successes (international reputation). However, it introduces a "priority" hierarchy into education that Ireland has avoided. By favoring specific courses, the UK government is actively curating the shape of the graduate workforce, whereas Ireland's universal grant expansion supports student choice across all disciplines.

2.3 Comparative Funding Architecture

Feature	Republic of Ireland (Fine Gael Model)	United Kingdom (Labour Model)
Core Philosophy	**Public Good:** Education funded by State & Employers to ensure broad access.	**Economic Engine:** Education funded by beneficiaries (students/graduates) and cross-subsidy.
Tuition Fees	**Reducing:** Gradual reduction of €3,000 contribution; increased grant coverage.	**Stabilizing:** Fees increased to £9,535 to track inflation and prevent insolvency.[12]
Maintenance Support	**Universal/Means-Tested:** SUSI grants available across all accredited courses.	**Targeted/Strategic:** Grants restricted to "Priority Courses" (Industrial Strategy alignment).
Funding Mechanism	**National Training Fund:** Surplus from employer levy supports HE/FE.[3]	**International Student Levy:** Flat fee on non-domestic students funds domestic grants.[9]
Institutional Status	**Unified:** TUs and Universities have equal legal standing; seamless transfer.	**Binary:** Distinction remains between Universities and new "Technical Excellence Colleges."

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3. Special Educational Needs (SEND) and Inclusion: Structures of Support

The domain of Special Educational Needs (SEN) represents a critical pressure point for both governments. The policies enacted by Hildegarde Naughton in Ireland and Bridget Phillipson in the UK reflect different stages of systemic maturity. Ireland is moving toward a qualitative deepening of support (therapy in schools), while the UK is engaged in a quantitative expansion of capacity (places).

3.1 Ireland: Hildegarde Naughton and the Therapeutic Shift

Hildegarde Naughton, serving initially as Minister of State for Special Education and Inclusion and later as Minister for Education and Youth (following Helen McEntee's tenure in late 2025), has overseen a fundamental shift in how support is delivered.

3.1.1 The Educational Therapy Support Service (ETSS)

Naughton's tenure is defined by the move from a "care" model to a "therapeutic" model. Previously, schools relied on Special Needs Assistants (SNAs) for care support, while therapeutic needs (Speech and Language, Occupational Therapy) were the domain of the

health service (HSE), often resulting in long waiting lists.

- **In-School Therapists:** The establishment of the **Educational Therapy Support Service (ETSS)** recruited 39 therapists and 5 behavior practitioners directly into the National Council for Special Education (NCSE) on a permanent basis.[13]
- **Regional Hubs:** Operating out of hubs in Dublin and Limerick, these therapists do not just treat children; they build capacity in teachers. They model interventions in the classroom, ensuring that therapeutic strategies are embedded in the daily curriculum rather than isolated in weekly appointments.[13]

3.1.2 The School Inclusion Model (SIM)

This service underpins the **School Inclusion Model (SIM)**, which categorizes support into tiers:

- **Tier 1:** Whole-school strategies for all students.
- **Tier 2:** Targeted groups.
- **Tier 3:** Intensive individualized support. Naughton's reforms ensure that "inclusion" is not merely about presence in a mainstream class but about participation enabled by onsite therapeutic expertise.[13]

3.1.3 Capital Investment under the NDP

Upon becoming Minister for Education and Youth in late 2025, Naughton published the *NDP Sectoral Investment Plan (2026–2030)*. This committed €7.55 billion to school infrastructure. Crucially, the plan mandated a "strong special education dimension" in all 105 priority projects, ensuring that no new school is built without appropriate sensory, therapeutic, and special class facilities.[14]

3.2 United Kingdom: Bridget Phillipson's Capacity Reconstruction

In the UK, the Labour government faced a SEND system described as "broken," characterized by an adversarial relationship between parents and local authorities and a severe shortage of state-funded places.

3.2.1 The £3 Billion Capital Injection

Phillipson's primary response was capital-intensive. The government committed over £3 billion to create **50,000 new specialist places**.[15]

- **Resource Bases:** A key innovation is the move away from segregated special schools toward "Resource Bases" attached to mainstream schools. This allows children with complex needs to access specialist support while remaining integrated in their local community.[15]
- **Ending the "Postcode Lottery":** The investment is targeted at "cold spots" where provision is lowest, aiming to standardize access across the country.

3.2.2 Workforce Up-Skilling

Recognizing that physical places are insufficient, Phillipson allocated £200 million to train

mainstream teachers in SEND awareness and assistive technology.[17]

- **Early Identification:** The focus is on "upstream" intervention—training teachers to identify needs early (e.g., speech delays in reception) so that support can be provided before a statutory Education, Health and Care Plan (EHCP) is required.[18]
- **Oracy Focus:** Linked to the curriculum review, there is a strong emphasis on oral language skills, addressing the surge in communication difficulties post-pandemic.[19]

3.3 Comparative Analysis: Medical vs. Structural

Aspect	Ireland (Naughton/Fine Gael)	United Kingdom (Phillipson/Labour)
Model of Support	**Therapeutic Integration:** Therapists embedded in schools (ETSS) to work alongside teachers.	**Capacity Building:** Massive expansion of specialist places (50k) and teacher training.
Integration	**School Inclusion Model:** Multi-tiered support within existing schools.	**Resource Bases:** Specialist units attached to mainstream schools.
Workforce	**Permanent Recruitment:** NCSE hiring therapists directly.[13]	**Generalist Training:** £200m to upskill *all* teachers in SEND.[17]
Key Challenge	**Silo-Busting:** Overcoming the Health vs. Education divide.	**Trust:** Rebuilding parental trust in a litigious EHCP system.

Insight: Ireland's ETSS is a pioneering model that the UK could learn from. By employing therapists directly in education, Ireland bypasses the health service bottlenecks that plague the UK system. Conversely, the UK's commitment to training *every* teacher in SEND is a systemic strength that ensures inclusion is the responsibility of the many, not the few.

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4. School Attendance and Welfare: Data vs. Community

The post-pandemic era saw a "fracturing of the social contract" regarding school attendance in both nations. The responses from Helen McEntee (Ireland) and Bridget Phillipson (UK) highlight a divergence between data-driven technical solutions and holistic community support.

4.1 Ireland: Helen McEntee and the "Anseo" Framework

During her tenure as Minister for Education and Youth (Jan–Nov 2025), Helen McEntee prioritized the **Anseo** (Irish for "Here") framework.

4.1.1 The Multi-Dimensional Multi-Tiered System of Supports (MD-MTSS)

Anseo represents a shift from "truancy" management to "attendance" support. It is a sophisticated data-analytics framework that allows schools to:

- **Analyze Root Causes:** The system categorizes absences not just by number, but by driver (e.g., anxiety, transport, family health).[20]
- **Tiered Response:** It utilizes the same tiered logic as special education. Tier 1 encourages attendance generally; Tier 2 targets at-risk cohorts; Tier 3 supports chronic absentees with individualized plans.
- **Rollout:** Following a pilot, McEntee oversaw the rollout to 60 schools in late 2025, with a roadmap for national adoption by 2028.[21]

4.1.2 Legislative Reform: The Under-6s

McEntee also initiated amendments to the *Education (Welfare) Act 2000*. Previously, school attendance was not compulsory until age six. The reform aims to lower this age or bring children enrolled in infant classes under the remit of Tusla (Child and Family Agency) earlier. This closes a critical gap where poor attendance habits form before the state has legal standing to intervene.[22]

4.2 United Kingdom: Bridget Phillipson and "Best Start"

In the UK, Labour views attendance as a symptom of wider poverty and family instability. The response is less about tracking the child and more about supporting the household.

4.2.1 Best Start Family Hubs

Labour's strategy revives the "Sure Start" model under the banner of **Best Start Family Hubs**.

- **One-Stop Shops:** These hubs co-locate education, health, and social services. A parent dropping a child at nursery can also access debt advice, mental health support, or employment training.[24]
- **Theory of Change:** The logic is that by stabilizing the home environment, school attendance will naturally improve. It is a "whole-family" approach rather than a "school-child" approach.

4.2.2 Breakfast Clubs

A tangible measure introduced by Phillipson is the national rollout of **Free Breakfast Clubs** in every primary school.[25]

- **Mechanism:** This is a direct intervention to tackle "hunger" and "lateness." By providing a free meal before school, the government incentivizes early arrival and ensures children are physically ready to learn. It removes a morning friction point for low-income families.[26]

4.3 Comparative Insight

Ireland's approach (Anseo) is technical and school-centric. It empowers principals with data

to make local decisions. It is efficient but relies on the school having the resources to act on the data.
The UK's approach (Best Start) is community-centric. It requires heavy cross-departmental investment but addresses the root causes of absenteeism (poverty, hunger, chaotic home lives) that a school data system cannot fix.

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5. The Vocational and Skills Landscape: Governance and Prestige

The UK's skills landscape has long been characterized by fragmentation and policy churn. In 2024–2026, the Labour government explicitly looked to Ireland's stable governance model for inspiration.

5.1 Ireland: The Stability of SOLAS

Ireland's Further Education and Training (FET) sector is governed by **SOLAS**.

- **Stable Governance:** SOLAS acts as a "system manager," funding Education and Training Boards (ETBs) to deliver courses. It is insulated from political volatility by the **National Training Fund**, which ensures multi-year funding certainty.[27]
- **Agility:** The system can rapidly deploy initiatives like "Skills to Advance" (upskilling for those in employment) because the infrastructure (ETBs) is permanent and locally embedded.

5.2 United Kingdom: The Creation of Skills England

Recognizing the UK's deficiency, Labour established **Skills England** in 2024/25.[29]

- **Institutional mimicry:** Skills England is designed to mirror the coordinating role of SOLAS. It brings together central government, businesses, and unions to define the "national skills need".[30]
- **Technical Excellence Colleges (TECs):** To deliver these skills, Phillipson launched **Technical Excellence Colleges**. These are FE colleges that bid for specialist status in areas like nuclear energy, construction, or digital.[31]
- **Growth and Skills Levy:** The reform of the Apprenticeship Levy into a "Growth and Skills Levy" allows businesses to spend funds on modular, short-term training rather than just long-form apprenticeships.[33] This mirrors the flexibility of Ireland's NTF usage.

Insight: The UK is currently in a phase of *institutional building*, attempting to construct the kind of stable architecture (Skills England) that Ireland has enjoyed for a decade under SOLAS. The "Technical Excellence Colleges" are an attempt to create the "parity of esteem" for vocational training that Ireland has already legislated for through its Technological Universities.

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6. Cross-Border Cooperation: The British-Irish Council

While policy divergence is evident, the **British-Irish Council (BIC)** remains a vital artery for cooperation. The education sectors of both islands continue to share best practices, particularly in Early Years.

- **November 2025 Summit:** The BIC Early Years Ministerial meeting, attended by Irish and UK ministers, focused on "Help and Support for Young Children with Additional Needs".[19]
- **Shared Challenges:** Both jurisdictions face a teacher recruitment crisis. The UK's target to recruit 6,500 new teachers [35] and Ireland's initiatives to upskill SNAs are discussed in these forums to prevent a "poaching war" for talent.
- **Policy Transfer:** The UK's presentation on speech and language interventions at the 2025 summit directly informed discussions on Ireland's ETSS, illustrating a live feedback loop between the two administrations.[19]

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7. Strategic Learning: How Each Island Can Benefit

The comparison of these policy landscapes reveals clear opportunities for mutual learning. The following framework outlines how Fine Gael and Labour can leverage each other's innovations.

7.1 What the UK Can Learn from Ireland

1. The "Therapist-in-School" Model (ETSS): The UK's SEND crisis is exacerbated by the separation of NHS (health) and DfE (education) budgets. Children wait months for NHS speech therapy. The UK should emulate Ireland's **Educational Therapy Support Service**, where the education department employs therapists directly. This would break the NHS bottleneck and ensure therapy is delivered in the classroom context.[13]

2. The National Training Fund (NTF): The UK's Apprenticeship Levy is often criticized as a tax that disappears into the Treasury. Ireland's NTF is a transparent, ring-fenced fund that generates a surplus used for higher education innovation. Adopting this transparency would build trust with UK employers.[4]

3. The Unified Tertiary System: Ireland's Technological Universities offer degrees from Level 6 (certificate) to Level 10 (PhD). The UK maintains a rigid divide between FE Colleges and Universities. The UK should look to the TU model to see how "Technical Excellence Colleges" could eventually grant their own degrees, raising their status and attractiveness.[6]

7.2 What Ireland Can Learn from the UK

1. Strategic Targeting (The "Priority" Model): Ireland's universal grants are generous but indiscriminate. The UK's **Targeted Maintenance Grants** for courses aligned with industrial strategy (e.g., green energy, healthcare) [9] offer a model for how Ireland could incentivize students into critical shortage areas. Ireland could introduce "Premium SUSI Grants" for

strategic subjects.
2. Whole-Family Integration (Family Hubs): Ireland's "First 5" strategy is excellent on paper, but services remain fragmented. The UK's **Best Start Family Hubs** [24] provide a physical infrastructure where health, education, and social support co-exist. Ireland should pilot co-locating Public Health Nurses and Social Welfare officers within primary school campuses in DEIS (disadvantaged) areas.
3. Oracy and Curriculum Reform: The UK's **Curriculum and Assessment Review** places a massive emphasis on "Oracy" (speaking skills) as a tool for social mobility.[36] As Ireland reforms its Leaving Certificate, it should consider making Oracy a distinct, assessed component to ensure students can articulate their knowledge, not just write it down.

7.3 Shared Learning: Teacher Recruitment

Both nations are struggling to staff their schools.

- **UK Innovation:** The UK's aggressive branding campaign and "reset" of the relationship with unions under Labour.[37]
- **Irish Innovation:** Ireland's move to make posts permanent (as seen with the ETSS therapists) to attract talent.[13] Combining these—marketing the profession while offering secure, permanent tenure—is the optimal strategy for both.

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8. Conclusion: A Republic of Opportunity vs. Breaking Barriers

The educational landscapes of Ireland and the UK in 2026 are defined by a shared recognition that the status quo of 2020 was unsustainable. However, the solutions reflect the distinct political DNA of Fine Gael and Labour.
In Ireland, **Simon Harris**, **Helen McEntee**, and **Hildegarde Naughton** have built a system that relies on **stability and integration**. They have rejected the marketization of higher education finance, integrated therapeutic health services into schools, and used data (Anseo) to manage attendance. It is a "steady state" expansion of the social contract, characterized by the "Republic of Opportunity"—a safety net that becomes a springboard.
In the UK, **Bridget Phillipson** has adopted a strategy of **reconstruction and targeting**. Inheriting a system marked by crumbling infrastructure and strikes, she has used the "Mission to Break Down Barriers" to justify radical interventions: the **International Student Levy**, the creation of **Skills England**, and the **Family Hub** rollout. These are attempts to engineer equity in a system that was previously left to the market.
As both nations move toward 2030, the British-Irish Council remains the essential forum for translating these experiments into shared success. Whether it is Ireland adopting the UK's industrial targeting or the UK adopting Ireland's therapeutic integration, the cross-pollination of ideas between Dublin and London remains one of the most under-utilized assets in European education policy.

Table 1: Comparative Policy Matrix (2024-2026)

Policy Domain	Republic of Ireland (Fine Gael / Coalition)	United Kingdom (Labour)
Higher Ed Funding	**Funding the Future:** No loans, reduced fees, core state funding + NTF.[3]	**Financial Stability:** Fee increase to £9.5k, targeted grants via International Levy.[9]
Vocational Governance	**SOLAS:** Mature, centralized agency managing FE & Apprenticeships.[27]	**Skills England:** New body established to centralize and regulate skills market.[29]
Inclusion (SEND)	**ETSS:** Therapists employed directly by schools/NCSE.[13]	**Capacity:** £3bn capital fund for 50k places; focus on teacher training.[16]
Attendance	**Anseo:** School-led, data-driven frameworks (MD-MTSS).[20]	**Best Start:** Community-led Family Hubs + Breakfast Clubs to tackle root causes.[24]
Key Ministers	Harris (HE Architect), Naughton (Inclusion/Ed), McEntee (Attendance).	Phillipson (Overall Reform), Baroness Smith (Skills).
Philosophy	"Enabling Opportunity" (Safety nets + Pathways).[1]	"Breaking Barriers" (Class ceiling removal + Structural Reform).[2]

End of Report

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